ministers and legislators to attend every sub-district-level Zoom meeting, each of which involved a few hundred workers. ‘It is compulsory for them to attend,’ said a district vice president in Mathura proudly. ‘Even ministers and MPs are not exempt. Then only there will be motivation. Even Hemaji [Hema Malini, Bollywood actress and Mathura MP] had to attend. If only karyakartas and those at the bottom are made to sit in such meetings and those on the top are exempt, they will question what is the point.’[47] The BJP saw these virtual meetings as much as an internal HR measure as it was a tool of political mobilisation. A district-level leader in UP explained the organisational purpose of these daily digital Zoom conversations during the lockdown:[48]

The main point is that between karyakarta and party, saamanjasya [coordination] should not break. If saamanjasya breaks, then bad feelings will take over. At this time, there are bad feelings about this Corona epidemic. Everybody is troubled. That should not take birth. If the karyakarta breaks away, then it’s a problem. The karyakarta should not break. That is why this is done to keep in sampark [contact] with the karyakarta.

Even if they don’t listen to him, and the neta says what he wants to say, but the conversation is on. The karyakarta feels at least they are heard somewhat and some conversation is on. Many karyakartas are happy that at least they got some hearing like this. Through Zoom app many are happy that at least somebody met them, saw them. He feels obliged that he is being taken seriously. This is digital India and a digital party.

Crucially, during the lockdown, at least in UP, the BJP continued its targeted outreach to beneficiaries of government schemes, which had powered its politics in the state before the pandemic. It simply switched to having the Labharthee Sammelans on Zoom. The high penetration of mobile phones in rural UP and the availability of digitised lists with phone numbers enabled this. It was one reason why, even as the Coronavirus ravaged the economy in 2020, the BJP leaders I met in UP remained confident that they had not been damaged too much politically (this was before the second wave of